Haligric Research Integration Series

SAN / BUSHMEN

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

Southern Africa — The Oldest Living Human Culture, the Rock Art Shamanic Maps, and the Trance Dance

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The San have been in southern Africa for at least 150,000 years — the oldest continuously distinct human lineage on Earth.

Their rock art, painted across tens of thousands of sites, is the longest continuous artistic tradition documented anywhere.

It is not decoration. It is a shamanic map — the visual record of trance journeys, painted by those who traveled and returned.

The trance dance is still danced most nights somewhere in the Kalahari.

The oldest healing technology on Earth is still practiced.

Contents

Introduction — The Oldest Living Culture on Earth....3
Who the San Are — Languages and Major Groups....3
San Territory — The Kalahari and the Rock Shelter Landscape....3
San Cosmology — The Three-Tiered Universe....3
//Kaggen — The Mantis Creator....4
N/om — The Sacred Potency....4
The Rock Art — A Shamanic Map of Consciousness, Decoded....4
The Trance Dance (Gia) — Complete Step-by-Step....5
Death and Transition in San Belief....5
San Storytelling and the /Xam Oral Literature....5
Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice....6
Legacy and Influence....6
Controversies and Fairness....6
Closing....7

Introduction — The Oldest Living Culture on Earth

The San — also called Bushmen, a term with a complicated colonial history that some San communities have reclaimed and others avoid in favor of San or specific group names — are the indigenous people of southern Africa and, in a specific and well-documented sense, the oldest continuous human culture on Earth. Genetic studies, including Carina Schlebusch and colleagues' comprehensive work published in Science (2017) and subsequent ancient-genome research through 2025, place the San as the most ancient branch of the human family tree, with continuous lineage in southern Africa extending back approximately 150,000–300,000 years.

This means the San trance dance, rock art tradition, and healing practice built around the sacred potency n/om are not exotic curiosities — they are the oldest surviving window available anywhere into the sacred practices of humanity itself. The oldest known ochre-working sites in southern Africa, at Pinnacle Point and Blombos Cave, date to roughly 100,000–160,000 years ago; the rock art itself spans a period from at least 27,000 years ago into the contact period, making it the longest continuous artistic tradition on Earth by a wide margin.

Who the San Are — Languages and Major Groups

'San' is a collective term for a number of related but distinct hunter-gatherer peoples of southern Africa, historically grouped with the pastoralist Khoikhoi as 'Khoisan' on the basis of shared click-consonant languages, though 'Khoisan' is now understood by linguists to describe a set of unrelated language families rather than a single genetic or linguistic unit. Major San peoples include the !Kung (Ju/'hoansi) of Namibia and Botswana, the /Xam of the historical Cape region (now extinct as a spoken-language community but extensively documented), the G/wi and G//ana of the Central Kalahari, and numerous smaller groups.

San click languages are among the most phonologically distinctive in the world and are severely endangered: /Xam itself has no remaining first-language speakers, and several other San languages have only a handful of elderly speakers remaining, driving active but under-resourced documentation and revitalization efforts across South Africa, Namibia, and Botswana.

San Territory — The Kalahari and the Rock Shelter Landscape

San communities are concentrated across the Kalahari Desert and surrounding regions of Botswana, Namibia, and South Africa, with smaller populations in Angola, Zambia, and Zimbabwe. The Kalahari is not a true desert in the strictest sense but a semi-arid savanna that historically supported a hunter-gatherer economy through deep, specialized ecological knowledge of seasonal water sources, edible plants, and game movement — knowledge increasingly displaced as San communities have been resettled off traditional land over the past half-century.

San Cosmology — The Three-Tiered Universe

San cosmology, reconstructed primarily from the extraordinary oral literature collected by Wilhelm Bleek and Lucy Lloyd in the 1870s from /Xam informants in Cape Town, together with more recent ethnographic work among the !Kung of the Kalahari, describes a universe organized into three interpenetrating tiers accessible to the trained practitioner through the trance dance.

The upper world (sky world) is the realm of //Kaggen, the ancestor spirits, and the sacred potency from which healing is drawn; the n/om-kxao (healer-in-trance) travels there along a 'thread of light' or 'rope to God.' The middle world is the everyday human world, understood as interpenetrated by spirit presences invisible to the ordinary person but perceptible to the healer in trance. The lower world is the underwater realm — home to the rain animal and other powerful, sometimes dangerous forces the n/om-kxao may also encounter in deep trance.

//Kaggen — The Mantis Creator

The most important supernatural figure in /Xam sacred narrative is //Kaggen — a complex trickster-creator who appears in the form of a praying mantis, who made the moon, and who embodies both the creative and disruptive dimensions of the sacred world. Like Coyote in North American traditions and Anansi in West African and Caribbean traditions, //Kaggen is simultaneously the maker of the world and the source of its complications — a figure whose stories are neither simple morality tales nor straightforward cosmogony, but explorations of how creativity and disorder are bound together.

N/om — The Sacred Potency

N/om is the single most important concept in San sacred practice: a sacred energy present throughout the living world, concentrated in certain animals (above all the eland), in certain people (n/om-kxao — those who carry n/om), in certain plants and places, and in the divine world itself. It is not identical to chi, prana, or comparable life-force concepts in Asian traditions, though it shares family resemblance — n/om is specifically linked to healing capacity and to the power to travel between the three tiers of the universe.

In !Kung tradition, n/om is described as residing in the belly and base of the spine in ordinary consciousness, as a viscous, warm substance that must be 'boiled' or 'heated' through the trance dance before it can rise up the spine to the head, at which point it enables the healer to enter the spirit world and carry out healing work. The sensation of n/om boiling is described by n/om-kxao as intensely painful — a burning, trembling, overwhelming experience that is simultaneously the most powerful and most dangerous moment of the trance; in its fully activated state n/om is understood as potentially fatal to those who cannot manage it, which is why novice healers train for years under the direct support of experienced n/om-kxao during the dance. The eland is understood to carry an extraordinary concentration of n/om, which is why it is the most sacred animal in San tradition and why eland imagery dominates the rock art.

The Rock Art — A Shamanic Map of Consciousness, Decoded

Southern Africa's rock paintings — created over at least 27,000 years and documented at more than 14,000 sites in South Africa alone, with tens of thousands more across the region — are the most extensively studied body of rock art in the world. For most of the twentieth century, Western scholars read them as hunting magic or straightforward records of daily life. The decisive reinterpretation came from David Lewis-Williams in the 1970s–1980s, who demonstrated, by cross-referencing the images against the documented /Xam oral literature and against !Kung ethnographic accounts of the trance dance, that the art is primarily a record of trance experience.

The paintings correspond to the three recognized stages of trance: entoptic phenomena (geometric patterns — grids, dots, zigzags, spirals — produced by the visual cortex in early trance, appearing as borders and background elements); construal (the geometric forms beginning to be perceived as meaningful images — a zigzag becoming a serpent, a grid

becoming a honeycomb); and full trance (represented by specific metaphorical imagery confirmed by San oral literature and ethnography — figures falling or bleeding from the nose to depict the healer's symbolic death, transformation into animal form, particularly the eland, and flying or floating figures representing the out-of-body spirit journey). The eland is the most frequently depicted animal not because it was the most commonly hunted, but because it is the n/om-richest animal and the one most closely bound to the trance experience itself; the largest and most elaborate paintings consistently pair elands with human figures shown in clear states of trance.

The Trance Dance (Gia) — Complete Step-by-Step

The trance dance — called the gia in !Kung, also known as the healing or n/om dance — is the central ceremony of San sacred practice: the collective ritual through which n/om is activated in the healers, through which they travel to the spirit world, and through which healing is transmitted to the community. It is among the most thoroughly documented shamanic healing ceremonies in the world, studied over decades of sustained anthropological fieldwork among the !Kung.

The dance is called when someone is ill, when the community needs spiritual renewal, or when the n/om-kxao feel its pull, occurring several times a month in traditional communities. All community members participate: women sit around the central fire singing the specific n/om songs that activate n/om's qualities, clapping the rhythmic foundation, while men — primarily the n/om-kxao — dance around the fire in a shuffling, stamping circuit with ankle rattles that gradually intensifies. After an hour or several hours, the n/om-kxao feel n/om heating — a burning sensation rising from the belly up the spine, with trembling and heavy sweating — and as n/om reaches the head the healer approaches kiai, or 'half-death,' a genuinely dangerous threshold at which other n/om-kxao catch and physically hold those who fall.

In full kiai the healer's spirit travels to the spirit world — ascending the thread of light to the upper world, descending to the underwater world, or moving through the invisible dimension of the ordinary world where harmful forces become directly perceptible — to perceive and engage the specific forces causing illness or disruption: pulling sickness out, driving away malevolent influence, retrieving lost soul components, or communicating with ancestors on behalf of the living. Healers then return to ordinary consciousness, sometimes gradually and sometimes with convulsion, supported by those in lighter trance states; they report what they perceived and what remedies or actions are required, and the dance may cycle again — a full night's ceremony often involves several such cycles, closing at dawn or once the community's needs have been addressed, with no formal closing rite beyond the natural subsiding of n/om.

Death and Transition in San Belief

San belief holds that death is a transition rather than an ending: the deceased's presence remains accessible to the living, particularly through the n/om-kxao's trance journeys, which may involve direct communication with ancestor spirits on behalf of the sick or the community. There is no elaborate San funerary architecture comparable to traditions with fixed temples or monumental tombs; the emphasis falls instead on the ongoing, actively worked relationship between the living community and its dead, maintained through the same trance technology that structures San healing more broadly.

San Storytelling and the /Xam Oral Literature

Sacred narrative is central to San cultural transmission, carried entirely through oral performance rather than written text. The single most important documentary record of this tradition is the Bleek and Lloyd Collection: more than 12,000 pages of /Xam narrative,

myth, and personal testimony recorded in the 1870s by the linguist Wilhelm Bleek and his sister-in-law Lucy Lloyd, working directly with /Xam informants — several of them prisoners at the Cape, whose collaboration with Bleek and Lloyd is itself now studied as a significant and ethically complex episode in the history of anthropology. The collection remains the primary source for reconstructing /Xam cosmology, including the //Kaggen narratives, and is held today by the University of Cape Town, with ongoing digitization and public-access projects making it more widely available to San communities and researchers alike.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

For the San, the trance dance functions simultaneously as the community's primary religious ceremony and its primary healthcare system — literal medical and psychological treatment for the sick, a setting for intense communal bonding during a physically demanding all-night ritual, and a shared cultural technology maintained without any formal institutional structure, clergy, or fixed doctrine. It is, among the traditions surveyed in this series, arguably the most direct and unmediated model of community-based spiritual healthcare documented anywhere.

Deep ecological and botanical knowledge — of edible and medicinal plants, of water sources, of animal behavior — is inseparable from San daily wellness practice and has itself become the subject of significant international attention and dispute (see Controversies and Fairness, below, on the Hoodia case).

Legacy and Influence

San rock art is recognized as one of humanity's oldest and most extensive bodies of religious visual expression, with major sites across South Africa, Namibia, Lesotho, and Botswana under active heritage protection, several holding UNESCO World Heritage status. David Lewis-Williams's shamanic decoding of the art fundamentally reshaped rock-art studies worldwide and is now the dominant interpretive framework applied to comparable trance-related rock art traditions on other continents.

San genetic and archaeological research continues to reshape scientific understanding of early modern human history: ancient-genome studies published through 2025 have further clarified the deep population structure and long-term regional isolation of San ancestors in southern Africa, reinforcing the San's documented status as carrying the most ancient continuously distinct human lineage identified to date.

Controversies and Fairness

The San face an entrenched, decades-long land and water rights struggle in Botswana. The government's creation and administration of the Central Kalahari Game Reserve led to San evictions beginning in the 1990s and early 2000s; Botswana's High Court ruled in 2006 that San residents had the right to live in and access the reserve, but the government subsequently restricted water access (San were for a period required to travel long distances outside the reserve for water) and hunting permits, restrictions international advocacy organizations including Survival International have characterized as a de facto continuation of displacement pressure by administrative means rather than outright eviction.

The discovery and commercialization of Hoodia gordonii — a Kalahari succulent San communities have used for generations to suppress hunger and thirst on long hunting trips — became one of the most closely watched test cases in international intellectual-property and indigenous-rights law. South Africa's Council for Scientific and Industrial Research patented Hoodia's active compound and licensed it to pharmaceutical partners for appetite-

suppressant drug development without initially involving or compensating San communities; following advocacy and negotiation, a 2003 benefit-sharing agreement between the South African San Council and CSIR established royalty payments to San communities, making it one of the first formal benefit-sharing agreements recognizing indigenous traditional knowledge under South African and international frameworks — though it remains contested, with critics noting the eventual commercial product underperformed and that comparable benefit-sharing arrangements for other San traditional knowledge have not consistently followed.

In 2014, a large diamond mine developed by Gem Diamonds began operating at Gope, inside the Central Kalahari Game Reserve, on land from which San communities had been removed — a development campaigners including Survival International cited as contradicting the Botswanan government's stated conservation rationale for the earlier evictions, since the same land was found suitable for extractive industry shortly after San residents were relocated.

San click languages are severely endangered, with /Xam having no remaining first-language speakers and several related languages down to a small number of elderly speakers; documentation and revitalization work is ongoing but significantly under-resourced relative to the scale of loss.

Closing

One hundred fifty thousand years. The same rock shelters, the same ochre, the same songs heating the same n/om in the same bodies under the same southern African stars. The trance dance still moves around the fire in the Kalahari. The rock art still covers the walls of ten thousand shelters. The eland still carries the n/om the painter saw in trance and recorded in ochre before any other documented civilization left a mark. The water is still contested, the land is still litigated, and the oldest healing technology on Earth is still practiced.